

Team Roles in a Nutshell

Ever wondered why some teams just seem to work and others hit the rocks? When things don't work, it is obvious to all and it often has a profound effect on the people involved, as well as the project or objective to be achieved.

In the 1970s, Dr Meredith Belbin and his research team at Henley Management College set about observing teams, with a view to finding out where and how these differences come about. They wanted to control the dynamics of teams to discover if – and how – problems could be pre-empted and avoided.



Over a period of nine years, international management teams were studied. Each participant completed a battery of psychometric tests, so that attributes such as personality and behaviour could be brought into play and their effects on the team could be accurately considered.

As the research progressed, the research revealed that the difference between success and failure for a team was not dependent on factors such as intellect, but more on behaviour. The research team began to identify separate clusters of behaviour, each of which formed distinct team contributions or "Team Roles". A **Team Role** came to be defined as: **"A tendency to behave, contribute and interrelate with others in a particular way."** It was found that different individuals displayed different Team Roles to varying degrees.

The first Team Role to be identified was the **"Plant"**. The role was so-called because one such individual was "planted" in each team. They tended to be highly creative and good at solving problems in unconventional ways.

One by one, the other Team Roles began to emerge. The **Monitor Evaluator** was needed to provide a logical eye, make impartial judgements where required and to weigh up the team's options in a dispassionate way. **Co-ordinators** were needed to focus on the team's objectives, draw out team members and delegate work appropriately.

When the team was at risk of becoming isolated and inwardly-focused, **Resource Investigators** provided inside knowledge on the opposition and made sure that the team's idea would carry to the world outside the team. **Implementers** were needed to plan a practical, workable strategy and carry it out as efficiently as possible. **Completer Finishers** were most effectively used at the end of a task, to "polish" and scrutinise the work for errors, subjecting it to the highest standards of quality control. **Teamworkers** helped the team to gel, using their versatility to identify the work required and complete it on behalf of the team. Challenging individuals, known as **Shapers**, provided the necessary drive to ensure that the team kept moving and did not lose focus or momentum.

Whilst some Team Roles were more “high profile” and some team members shouted more loudly than others, each of the behaviours was essential in getting the team successfully from start to finish. The key was balance. For example, Meredith Belbin found that a team with no Plant struggled to come up with the initial spark of an idea with which to push forward. However, once too many Plants were in the team, bad ideas concealed good ones and non-starters were given too much airtime. Similarly, with no Shaper, the team ambled along without drive and direction, missing deadlines. With too many Shapers, in-fighting began and morale was lowered.

As well as the strength or contribution they provided, each Team Role was also found to have an **“allowable weakness”**: a flipside of the behavioural characteristics, which is allowable in the team because of the strength which goes with it. For example, the unorthodox Plant could be forgetful or scatty; or the Resource Investigator might forget to follow up on a lead. Co-ordinators might get over-enthusiastic on the delegation front and Implementers might be slow to relinquish their plans in favour of positive changes. Completer Finishers, often driven by anxiety to get things right, were found to take their perfectionism to extremes. Teamworkers, concerned with the welfare and morale of the team, found it difficult to make decisions where this morale might be compromised or team politics, involved. Shapers risked becoming aggressive and bad-humoured in their attempts to get things done.

It was only after the initial research had been completed that the ninth Team Role, **“Specialist”** emerged. The simulated management exercises had been deliberately set up to require no previous knowledge. In the real world, however, the value of an individual with in-depth knowledge of a key area came to be recognised as yet another essential team contribution or Team Role. Just like the other Team Roles, the Specialist also had a weakness: a tendency to focus narrowly on their own subject of choice, and to prioritise this over the team’s progress.

The Team Roles that Meredith Belbin identified are used widely in thousands of organisations all over the world today. By identifying our Team Roles, we can ensure that we **use our strengths to advantage and that we manage our weaknesses as best we can**. Sometimes, this means being aware of the pitfalls and making an effort to avoid them.

Most people have a number of “preferred Team Roles” or behaviours they frequently and naturally display. We also have “manageable roles”, roles which might not be the most natural course of behaviour for us, but which we can assume if required and might wish to cultivate. Lastly, we have least preferred roles, those we should not assume, since we’ll be playing against type. In this instance, the effort is likely to be great, and the outcome, poor. If work requires Team Roles other than our own, it is a much better bet to find and work with others who possess roles complementary to our own. Since people tend to display more than one preferred role, a team of four could quite easily represent all nine Belbin Team Roles.

So, in a nutshell, the Belbin philosophy is about celebrating – and making the most of – individual differences. The message is that there is room for everyone in the team: all positive contributions are welcome.



Team Role Summary Descriptions

Team Role	Contribution	Allowable Weaknesses
Plant 	Creative, imaginative, free-thinking. Generates ideas and solves difficult problems.	Ignores incidentals. Too preoccupied to communicate effectively.
Resource Investigator 	Outgoing, enthusiastic, communicative. Explores opportunities and develops contacts.	Over-optimistic. Loses interest once initial enthusiasm has passed.
Co-ordinator 	Mature, confident, identifies talent. Clarifies goals. Delegates effectively.	Can be seen as manipulative. Offloads own share of the work.
Shaper 	Challenging, dynamic, thrives on pressure. Has the drive and courage to overcome obstacles.	Prone to provocation. Offends people's feelings.
Monitor Evaluator 	Sober, strategic and discerning. Sees all options and judges accurately.	Lacks drive and ability to inspire others. Can be overly critical.
Teamworker 	Co-operative, perceptive and diplomatic. Listens and averts friction.	Indecisive in crunch situations. Avoids confrontation.
Implementer 	Practical, reliable, efficient. Turns ideas into actions and organises work that needs to be done.	Somewhat inflexible. Slow to respond to new possibilities.
Completer Finisher 	Painstaking, conscientious, anxious. Searches out errors. Polishes and perfects.	Inclined to worry unduly. Reluctant to delegate.
Specialist 	Single-minded, self-starting, dedicated. Provides knowledge and skills in rare supply.	Contributes only on a narrow front. Dwells on technicalities.

Things 'To do' and 'Not to do'

Team Role	Do...	Don't...
Plant 	Come up with ideas and suggestions for solving problems and working out solutions. Invent a new way of tackling the issues in hand. Create an original piece of work. Look at things from a different angle.	Evaluate your own ideas. Have strong ownership of your own ideas when co-operation with others would yield better results.
Resource Investigator 	Go outside the group to initiate new contacts. Develop the ideas of the PLANT. Use your enthusiasm to build up other people's enthusiasm. Search out new markets. Negotiate with others.	Let people down by neglecting to follow up arrangements. Talk too much so others cannot get enough air time.
Co-ordinator 	Establish an air of authority over the team with your mature approach. Bring others into discussions when they have things to contribute. Hold the group together. Praise and encourage others.	Take credit for the effort of the team. Overplay your status. Neglect to do your fair share of the work.
Shaper 	Get things moving. Stop complacency and laziness. Be honest, straightforward and open with others. Make sure the team is achieving goals. Push things forward.	Hold grudges, become overbearing. Lose your sense of humour when the going gets tough.
Monitor Evaluator 	Provide a balanced opinion on all ideas and options. Be ready to explain what actions you prefer and why. Stop ill thought out courses of action. Take your time over your decisions.	Be seen by the team as a cynic. Give a negative reaction to everything you hear. Dampen the positive approach of the team.
Teamworker 	Promote good team atmosphere by reacting to the needs of others. Support members of the group when necessary. Become a broker in times of argument, and defuse any hostility.	Avoid situations that may entail pressure. Side with the most dominant in a desire to please.
Implementer 	Organise systems. Ensure you and others follow the laid out procedures. Get down to the practical issues. Try and turn ideas into action. Be loyal to your organisation and people within it.	Obstruct change. Be resistant to new ideas of the team. Be seen as a "stick in the mud".
Completer Finisher 	Try to raise standards in all you do. Concern yourself with detail. Use your ability to help other members of the team who may not be so strong on accuracy. Promote excellence.	Allow perfectionism to turn into obsessive behaviour. Penny pinch or split hairs on trivial issues.
Specialist 	Show your enthusiasm for a particular subject. Cultivate a sense of professionalism and encourage your fellow team members to trust your knowledge. Keep your expertise and skills up-to-date.	Discount the importance of factors outside your own area of competence. Become over protective of the boundaries of your job area.



Team Strengths:

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Team Weaknesses:

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Frequently Asked Questions

What are Belbin Team Roles?

A Team Role as defined by Dr Meredith Belbin is “A tendency to behave, contribute and interrelate with others in a particular way.”

The value of Belbin Team Role theory lies in enabling an individual or team to benefit from self-knowledge and adjust according to the demands being made by the external situation.

How did the concept originate?

The concept was derived from a study of successful and unsuccessful teams competing in Business Games at Henley Management College, England. Managers taking part in the exercise were given a battery of psychometric tests and put into teams of varying composition. As time progressed different clusters of behaviour were identified as underlying the success of the teams. These successful clusters of behaviour were then given names. Hence the emergence of nine Team Roles:

Action-oriented Roles:	Shaper	Implementer	Completer Finisher
People-oriented Roles:	Co-ordinator	Teamworker	Resource Investigator
Thinking-oriented Roles:	Plant	Monitor Evaluator	Specialist

What can be gained by identifying people's Team Roles?

It is difficult to work effectively with people without some reasonable expectations of how they are going to perform. Self and Observer Assessments show how an individual feels and how an individual behaves in a group.

Why use Observer Assessments?

Observer Assessments provide independent evidence about an individual's Team Roles. A Self-Perception test is only as good as an individual's sense of personal realism. Some people answer in terms of how they would like to contribute rather than how they really behave.

Can I change Team Roles?

Team Roles develop and mature. These may change with experience and conscious attention. Different Team Roles may come to the fore in response to the needs of particular situations.

Shall I let people know my preferred Team Roles?

The sharing of Team Roles increases understanding and enables mutual expectations to be met. Disappointments will then be less frequent.

What is an 'Allowable Weakness'?

Sometimes strength in one role has to be bought at the cost of what might be seen as a weakness in another context. For example, a person whose preferred Team Role is Monitor Evaluator is likely to be objective, impartial and good at carefully weighing up all possibilities to make the right decision. Yet someone with these strengths may well come across as being unenthusiastic or even boring. Any failure to inspire is apt to obscure the true strengths of a Monitor Evaluator. That weakness can be reckoned the price that necessarily has to be paid for the strength and in this sense it is termed Allowable.

What is a 'Team Role Sacrifice'?

In some circumstances an individual will need to forego using his/her leading or preferred Team Role and adopt another in its place. This shift may be rendered necessary due to the lack of a good example of a desired role within the team or because another person is already contributing on common preferred ground. Such a shift from preferred behaviour is known as "making a Team Role sacrifice".

When I know my strongest Team Roles, what shall I do about it?

A person's overall strongest roles are the ones most appreciated by other people. Develop and play these roles with enthusiasm, because this is where you are likely to make a mark. At the same time take note of your lowest roles and find a strategy to avoid exposure by trying to play them. So try to work with people who are strong in the roles in which you are weak.

What about the reliability and validity of BELBIN® Interplace?

Reliability and validity are concepts commonly used in evaluating Psychometric Tests. Reliability is a measure of the internal consistency of a test, while validity relates to whether a test measures what it purports to measure.

Internal consistency is highest where test items are repeated, but this narrows their focus. Rather than repeating questions, or dealing with items that are virtually identical, BELBIN® Interplace seeks to find clusters of useful forms of related behaviour. For example, the Shaper cluster refers to an individual who is challenging, competitive, hard driving, tough and outspoken. However, that does not mean that everyone who is competitive happens to be outspoken.

Most Psychometric Tests rely on self-reporting. But here the behaviour assumed may not correspond with what others observe. The strength of BELBIN® Interplace lies in its emphasis on validity, for its counselling outputs are designed to take account of a consensus on observed behaviour. This can be made evident by looking at how far the Observers agree with each other. Formal correlations are, however, difficult to calculate as Observers are not required to make any fixed number of responses. Genuine responses are more easily obtained, and are more valuable, when forced choices are avoided. Differences in perception between the self and others provide valuable leads for action.

The demands of jobs also have to be taken into account when assessing validity since the many varied forms of behaviour can be seen as effective or ineffective according to the context. Here the fit between the profile of the individual and the profile of the job plays a key consideration.